THE FEAR: Environmentalists are concerned about the diversion of 130.75 sq. km of forest land for the project, a move that could see the felling of 711,000 trees. They also question the rationale of compensatory afforestation in Haryana and Madhya Pradesh.

THE RESPONSE: MoEFCC says the diverted forestland is just 1.82 per cent of the total area of the A&N islands and that 82 per cent of GNI will remain under forest cover. Some 66 sq. km of the project area will also be designated green zones. The A&N administration has also prepared a mangrove conservation plan for GNI.



INDIA PICTURE



UNDER THREAT
MEGAPODE

Classified as 'Vulnerable' by the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN), this mostly terrestrial bird, about the size of a chicken, is known for its unique nesting behaviour: building them on large mounds of soil and decaying vegetation, relying on the heat generated by decomposition to incubate its eggs.

THE FEAR: The Nicobar Megapode typically nests close to the coast, building its incubation mounds in low-lying littoral areas. Any large-scale coastal construction could severely disrupt breeding sites, and could result in their possible extinction.

THE RESPONSE: MoEFCC has initiated a long-term scientific intervention, some 102 active nesting mounds have been mapped; those in the project influence areas are to be geo-referenced and protected. The 1.29 sq. km Menchal Island has also been designated a Megapode sanctuary.



> **"It is a conflict of interest to ask the agency [MoEFCC] that cleared the project to review the environmental clearances without adequate independent members"**

ASHISH KOTHARI
Environmentalist and petitioner in the NGT, while talking to INDIA TODAY *in 2024*

A CONTROVERSIAL GREENLIGHTING

The February 16 NGT verdict capped a three-year legal battle that began when noted environmentalist Ashish Kothari filed a petition challenging the project's environmental clearance. The tribunal upheld the clearance, but made it contingent on strict enforcement of the stringent safeguards prescribed therein. Hailing the NGT's decision, Bhupender Yadav, Union minister of environment, forests and climate change, told INDIA TODAY, "The project is of great defence, national security and strategic significance. It will strengthen India's presence in the Andaman Sea and Southeast Asia and create an economic hub with